

> **"WHEN A NEW STAR CAST CREATES WAVES AT THE BOX OFFICE, IT SENDS A CLEAR MESSAGE TO PRODUCERS NOT TO MAKE AN OVER-BUDGET FILM, MORE THAN A GOOD STORY NEEDS"**
>
> **SUBHASH GHAI**, *Filmmaker,* on X

a film with two twentysomething newcomers was a gamble they were willing to take. Casting director Shanoo Sharma, who has brought to Bollywood talents like Anushka Sharma, Ranveer Singh and Bhumi Pednekar, found the perfect pair in Panday (cousin of Ananya Panday) and Padda, whose earlier credit is a little-seen web series *Big Girls Don't Cry*. YRF was confident it had an ace up its sleeves with the genre it was once synonymous with—romance.

"It meant a lot to me that mine was the film with which YRF wanted to come back to the genre," says Suri. "My education in romantic films was going to theatres and watching Yash [Chopra] ji and Adi [Aditya] sir's films. We all grew up falling in love with the kind of films they did."

Interestingly, the young leads were spared the burden of a promotional blitz. "We wanted to take away those expectations," says Suri. "I think they have excelled. They have given it their all. They went all in, their hunger is there. They are more skilled and prepared than [we were when] we started out. They want their work to talk."

RETURN OF ROMANCE

And talk it has, with 27-year-old Panday, particularly, being celebrated as the next big thing. Much chatter has been around how the film could portend the return of romance in Hindi cinema. After all, not since *Kaho Naa Pyaar Hai*, 25 years back, has a love story with debutants been embraced with such gusto.

But the crystal ball remains hazy. *Kaho Naa...* came at the tail-end of a decade of love stories, in which Shah Rukh Khan led the wave with his trademark outstretched arms. In recent times, the only other Hindi romantic film to have connected so feverishly with audiences was Sandeep Reddy Vanga's *Kabir Singh* (2019), with its wild-child of a hero leaving some audiences unsettled by his rage and antics.

Yet the industry appears hopeful. "Thankfully, *Saiyaara* has made heads turn and made everyone realise that it's the big intrinsic idea that really drives the box office.... I hope it makes the industry realise that what we need is not one genre over and over again. We need to give audiences a variety," says Akkshay Rathie, director at Aashirwad Theatres and a film exhibitor. Annukampa Harsh, a fortysomething writer who saw the film with her mother, says that *Saiyaara* is proof that "the old school works.... We don't need 'modern' love stories. The only thing new about love today is how we seek it."

Whether any of the upcoming romantic films in the next few months (see *Love is in the Air*) will resonate the way *Saiyaara* has with the audiences remains to be seen. But what is clear right now is that Panday and Padda are two of the industry's brightest young stars basking in the success of a debut that could only have been written in the stars. ■

LOVE IS IN THE AIR

***Saiyaara*'s success has given a fillip to other films in the genre**

DHADAK 2, *Aug. 1*

Dharma brings its own take on star-crossed romance, albeit this one has caste as the source of dramatic conflict. Starring Triptii Dimri and Siddhant Chaturvedi





PARAM SUNDARI
Aug. 29

Maddock Films takes a break from horrror comedies to present a romcom featuring Janhvi Kapoor and Sidharth Malhotra

SUNNY SANSKARI KI TULSI KUMARI
Oct. 2

Varun Dhawan, Janhvi Kapoor, Sanya Malhotra and Rohit Saraf come together for this romantic comedy, which is directed by Shashank Khaitan

EK DIN, *Nov. 7*

After *Loveyapa*'s poor showing, Junaid Khan hopes to turn it around as a romantic hero with this adaptation of the Korean film *One Day*

TERE ISHQ MEIN, *Nov. 28*

Aanand L. Rai sure knows what it takes to make emotionally-charged love stories for the big screen. This one's got his *Raanjhana* star Dhanush and Kriti Sanon